of the island would be lifted. Dobrynin protested that such a solution was a nonstarter with Khrushchev, who wanted to avoid publicity. Robert understood that very well. He promised to talk to his brother, and in an hour and a half he was back at the embassy, where Dobrynin was hosting a reception honoring the Bolshoi Theater troupe then visiting Washington. Robert passed Dobrynin an oral message from Kennedy to Khrushchev: the United States would announce the lifting of the blockade if Khrushchev agreed to remove the bombers within thirty days. Robert Kennedy was now in a much better mood than during his previous visits to Dobrynin. After speaking with the ambassador, he joined the crowd at the reception for the Bolshoi troupe and even kissed the famous prima ballerina Maia Plisetskaia when he learned that they shared birthdays.[12]

Khrushchev called a Presidium meeting to discuss Kennedy's new proposal on November 14 and dictated a letter to Kennedy on the same day. "The question of the withdrawal of the IL-28s within the 30 days mentioned does not constitute any complicated question," began Khrushchev on a positive note, switching to a rather negative one almost on the fly: "Yet this period will probably not be sufficient." He asked for two or three months to complete the withdrawal. More importantly, he tried to bargain not only for the lifting of the blockade but also for a halt to American overflights of Cuba and a guarantee of noninvasion. "If we attain all that now and if this were announced, then more favorable conditions would be created for our country to solve the question of timetable for the withdrawal of IL-28 planes," wrote Khrushchev, doing Castro's bidding more than his own.

Once again Dobrynin met with Robert Kennedy to pass on Khrushchev's letter. Kennedy did not hide his displeasure with the response. "The President," he told Dobrynin, "will be disappointed by the answer when he receives it." John Kennedy was disappointed indeed. "The IL-28's are still in Cuba and are of deep concern to the people of our entire Hemisphere," wrote Kennedy in response. "Thus, three major parts of the undertakings on your side—the removal of the IL-28's, the arrangements for verification, and safeguards against introduction—have not yet been carried out." He concluded the letter in a constructive tone, promising negotiations on the noninvasion pledge once the immediate problem was resolved: "[T]he first step is to get the bombers started out, and the